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Fly mask for an animal

Abstract

A fly mask for an animal, such as a horse, is configured with a plurality of replaceable sections or panels. The sections are formed from breathable material, such as a mesh material that is at least partially light-transparent. The various sections are removably joined together by fasteners, such as hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips, and the like. Thus, when one or more of the sections of the fly mask are damaged, only that particular section or panel requires replacement. As a result, the majority of the fly mask that is not worn out or damaged can then be reused. This avoids the expense and environmental waste associated with disposing of and replacing the entire fly mask, which is highly desirable.

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) The various embodiments disclosed herein relate to accessories for animals. In particular, the various embodiments disclosed herein relate to fly masks for animals, such as horses. More particularly, the various embodiments disclosed herein relate to fly masks, which are constructed from individually removable sections that can be readily replaced with a new section.

BACKGROUND

(2) A fly mask has been used as a convenient accessory to not only protect the face of a horse, but to keep irritants and other debris, such as flies, out of its eyes. In fact, a fly mask can be worn by the horse when it is resting or sleeping, when it is active and running, such as when the horse is being ridden. While fly masks may be formed of material that is completely opaque, they are often formed of a mesh or porous type of material that has some amount of optical transparency to allow the horse to be able to visually see therethrough. Thus, not only do fly masks provide an extremely useful device that physically protects the eyes of a horse from airborne environmental hazards, they also serve to reduce the spread of airborne pathogens, thereby improving the quality of life and health of the horse.

(3) Unfortunately, these fly masks are susceptible to wear and tear from the movement of the horse and their interaction with various structures in their environment. For example, during the course of its daily life, a horse encounters and contacts many obstacles with its head, such as through brushing, hitting and rubbing up against fencing or other structural members that form its shelter or stall, as well as against the surfaces of transport vehicles, such as trailers, and the like. This abrasive interaction results in the wear of the fly mask, causing it to become damaged and worn out over time. In some cases, the area of the fly mask that receives a substantial amount of wear is the area of the fly mask that is fit over the horse's nose. As a result, even though the fly mask only experiences wear in a confined location, such as the horse's nose for example, it requires that the fly mask be completely replaced to ensure that it effectively provides protection to the horse, which is expensive and wasteful.

(4) Currently, some fly masks offer a removable nose section, which allows a horse's owner to remove the nose section of the fly mask for various reasons, including: the nose section is bothering or affecting the horse and making it uncomfortable; the fly mask does not properly fit the horse's head with the nose section attached; or the nose section is not needed, such as in the case when the horse is being boarded and is housed in a stall. Alternatively, in the case when the nose section of the fly mask is worn and requires replacement, it may be removed. Unfortunately, manufacturers of current fly masks that have removable nose sections do not offer replacement nose sections to replace them when they are worn out.

(5) Accordingly, to reduce the need to replace the entire fly mask when only a portion of the fly mask is experiencing wear, it would be desirable to provide fly masks where not only is the nose section removable, but other sections that form the fly mask are removable, and where all such sections are capable of being replaced with new corresponding sections. As such, offering fly masks that are configured with removable and replaceable sections would reduce the costs that would otherwise be associated with replacing the entire fly mask when only a specific portion of the fly mask, which has been exposed to substantial wear and tear only needs to be replaced. As a result, current fly masks cause substantial expense and environmental waste due to the entire fly mask needing replacement, often frequently, when in fact, only a portion of the overall fly mask is damaged or worn, which is highly undesirable.

(6) Therefore, there is a need for a fly mask that has multiple panels or sections, which can be replaced with a new section when they become worn out or damaged. In addition, there is a need for a fly mask that has a structure that is formed of replaceable panels or sections. Still more, there is a need for a fly mask that incorporates replaceable panels or sections that covers one or more portions of an animal's head, including but not limited to its face, nose, ears and head/crown. Furthermore, there is a need for a fly mask that has multiple panels or sections that can be replaced with panels or sections of different characteristics, such as size, color, shape, material, light opacity for example.

SUMMARY

(7) It is one aspect of the various embodiments disclosed herein to provide a fly mask for an animal having a pair of eyes including a first face section; a second face section removably attached to the first face section, wherein the first and second face sections are adapted to respectively cover the

eyes of the animal; and a fastener adapted to releasably join the first and second face sections together to retain the fly mask to the animal.

(8) It is another aspect of the various embodiments disclosed herein to provide a fly mask kit for an animal having a pair of eyes including a first face section and a second face section, wherein the first and second face sections are configured to be removably attached together, and are configured to be removably joined together to retain the first and second face sections around the head of the animal, such that the first and second face sections respectively cover the eyes of the animal; and a first crown section and a second crown section, wherein the first and second crown sections are configured to be removably attached together, and are configured to be removably attached to at least one of the first and second face sections, the first and second crown sections adapted to be positioned proximate to the crown of a head of the animal.

(9) It is yet another aspect of the various embodiments of fly mask kit for an animal having a pair of eyes including a first face section and a second face section, wherein the first and second face sections are configured to be removably attached together, and are configured to be removably joined together to retain the first and second face sections around the head of the animal, such that the first and second face sections respectively cover the eyes of the animal; and a support strap connecting the first face section to the second face section, whereby the support strap is adapted to rest upon a neck of the animal.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The various embodiments disclosed herein will become better understood with regard to the following description, accompanying drawings and claims, wherein:

(2) FIG. 1 is a top plan view of a fly mask in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(3) FIG. 2 is an exploded view of the fly mask in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(4) FIG. 2A is an exploded view of an alternative fly mask showing the fly mask with removable ear covers and exposed ear cover openings in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(5) FIG. 3 is a front perspective view of the fly mask when worn on the head of a horse in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(6) FIG. 4 is a side elevational view of the fly mask when worn on the head of a horse in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(7) FIG. 5 is another front perspective view of the fly mask worn by a horse, whereby a nose section provided by the fly mask is shown as being removed in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(8) FIG. 6 is another front perspective view of the fly mask worn by a horse, whereby the nose section and a crown mask section of the fly mask are removed leaving only the face mask section attached to the horse in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(9) FIG. 7A is a side elevation view of an alternative embodiment of the fly mask that does not utilize the crown sections, and that incorporates a support strap in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein;

(10) FIG. 7B is another side elevation view of the alternative embodiment of the fly mask shown in FIG. 7A showing the crown sections removably attached in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein; and

(11) FIG. 7C is an exploded view of the alternative embodiment of the fly mask shown in FIG. B in accordance with the various concepts disclosed herein.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(12) A fly mask in accordance with the various embodiments disclosed herein, which is to be worn by an animal, such as a horse **10**, is referred to by numeral **100** as shown in the FIGS. **1-7**. The fly mask **100** is designed to be worn over the entirety, or a portion of, a head **120** of the horse **10**. For example, the fly mask **100** may be configured, so as to cover the eyes **10A** of the horse **10**, as well as other portions of the horse's head, including its nose, face and crown. In particular, the mask **100** includes a body **200** that is formed of a plurality of removable sections **300** to be discussed in detail below. The sections **300** are configured to be removably joined to each other to form the complete structure of the fly mask **100**. Because the sections **300** are able to be readily removed, a particular individual section **300** of the fly mask **100** that becomes damaged or worn, can be removed and replaced, without the need to replace the entire structure of the fly mask **100**. It should be appreciated that while the discussion presented herein presents the fly mask **100** as being used with a horse **10**, the fly mask **100** may be used with any animal, such as a donkey, zebra, or the like.

(13) Face Sections:

(14) Specifically, the fly mask **100** includes a pair of face sections **300A** and **300B**, which are configured to be positioned over a face portion **310** of the horse **10**, so as to cover its eyes **10A**. The face sections **300A** and **300B** are mirror images of each other and may be formed of any suitable material to be discussed in detail below. In particular, the face section **300A** includes a face section attaching edge **400A**, a crown section attaching edge **410A**, a nose section attaching edge **420A**, and an exterior edge **425A**. Similarly, the face section **300B** includes a face section attaching edge **400B**, a crown section attaching edge **410B**, a nose section attaching edge **420B**, and an exterior edge **425B**. In addition, the face sections **300A** and **300B** have an outer surface **556** and an inner surface **557**.

(15) The face section attaching edges **400A-B**, the crown section attaching edges **410A-B**, and the nose section attaching edges **420A-B** of the face sections **300A-B** include any suitable releasable fastener **440**, such as a hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips, and the like. It should also be appreciated that the face section attaching edge **400A** and the face section attaching edge **400B** of the face sections **300A-B** are joined together by the fastener **440** to form the face mask portion **460A** of the fly mask **100**, as shown in FIG. **1**. In particular, as shown in FIG. **2**, the face section **300A** may include the fastener **440** on its outer surface **556** proximate to the face section attaching edge **400A**, and the crown section attaching edge **410A**, nose section attaching edge **420A**. In addition, the face section **300B** may include the fastener **440** its outer surface **556** proximate to the crown section attaching edge **410B** and the nose section attaching edge **420B**, while the fastener **440** is disposed on the inner surface **557** of the face section **300B** proximate to the face section attaching edge **400B**. However, it should be appreciated that such configuration should not be construed as limiting as the fastener **440** may be used in any suitable configuration desired.

(16) To secure the face sections **300A** and **300B** to the horse **10** are configured to each include a retention device or fastener **450**. In some embodiments, the fastener **450** may comprise snaps, zippers, clips, and the like that operate to selectively join the face sections **300A** and **300B** together about the head of the horse **10**. In other embodiments, the fastener **450** may include one retaining strap **450A** attached to the face section **300A**, such as to exterior edge **425A**, and another retaining strap **450B** attached to the face section **300B**, such as to the exterior edge **425B**. The straps **450A** and **450B** may be joined by a fastener **470**, which may be adjustable, and that allows a user to attach the straps together and to adjust the desired level of tightness imparted to the face sections **300A** and **300B** when they are positioned about the horse's head **120** and over its eyes **10A**. In other words, the retention system **450** may comprise a 2-piece retention strap system having straps **450A** and **450B** that respectively extend from the face section **300A** and the face section **300B**. The straps **450A** and **450B** may be formed of the same material as the mask sections **300** or may be formed from any other suitable material, such as leather, nylon, or the like; stretchable or resilient material;

as well as a combination thereof. In some embodiments, the fastener **470** utilized by the straps **450A** and **450B** to secure them together may comprise hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like, so as to secure the face sections **300A** and **300B** together and to retain the mask **100** to the face **310** of the horse **10**. Thus, when the face sections **300A** and **300B** are positioned on the horse **10**, so as to form the face mask portion **460A**, the straps **450A-B** are positioned under a lower jaw **479** and in front of a neck **480** of the horse **10**, to thereby retain the face mask portion **460A** to the face **310** of the horse **10**.

(17) In some embodiments, the straps **450A-B** may be replaced with a single section of resilient or stretchable material, such as elastic, that is configured to comfortably retain the face mask sections **300A-B** to the horse **100**.

(18) In addition, each eye protrusions **490A** and **490B** provided by the respective face sections **300A-B**, which are raised or elevated from the eyes **10A** of the animal **10** when the fly mask **100** is attached to the horse **100**. That is, the eye protrusions **490A** and **490B** provide a space or gap between the fly mask **100** and the animal's eyes **10A**. This prevents the fly mask **100** from contacting and possibly abrading and injuring the animal's eyes **10A** when the fly mask **100** is worn. In some embodiments, the protrusions **490A-B** may be configured as fabric darts that form a gathering of material. This creates a pucker or bulge in the material forming the face sections **300A-B** to thereby form the space or gap between the animal's eyes **10A** and the face sections **300A-B** of the fly mask **100**.

(19) It should also be appreciated that the protrusions **490A-B** may be configured as pre-formed molded regions or areas in the material forming the face sections **300A-B**. For example, the molded regions or areas forming the protrusions **490A-B** may comprise a rigid body, such as that formed of plastic for example, or may be molded or formed directly into the fabric or material that forms the face sections **300A-B**. The eye protrusions **490A-B**, such as the rigid/molded plastic protrusions are formed of transparent or at least partially transparent material to allow the horse **10** to see therethrough.

(20) It should also be appreciated that the rigid protrusions **490A-B** may be configured as inserts or lenses that may be snap-fit or friction-fit into corresponding apertures disposed in the face sections **300A-B** of the fly mask **100**. As such, the rigid protrusions may have different sizes, shapes, and opacities for light for example, to accommodate the particular preferences of the horse **10**.

(21) It is also contemplated that each face section **300A** and **300B** may be formed of multiple sections instead of the single section shown in the Figs., which are joined by the fastener **440**, which may include hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like.

(22) Crown Sections:

(23) The fly mask **100** also includes a pair of crown sections **300AA** and **300BB**, which are configured to fit over a crown **490** of the horse's head **120**. The crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** are mirror images of each other and may be formed of any suitable material to be discussed in detail below. In particular, the crown section **300AA** includes a face section attaching edge **510A**, a crown section attaching edge **520A**, and an exterior edge **525A**. Similarly, the crown section **300BB** includes a face section attaching edge **510B**, a crown section attaching edge **520B**, and an exterior edge **525B**. In addition, the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** have an outer surface **556** and an inner surface **557**.

(24) The face section attaching edges **510A-B** of the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** are configured to be removably attached to the crown section attaching edges **410A-B** respectively of the face sections **300A** and **300B** by the fastener **440**, which may include hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as, snaps, zippers, clips and the like. It should be appreciated that the crown section attaching edges **520A** and **520B** of the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** are configured to be removably attached together by the releasable fastener **440**, to form the crown mask portion **460B**, as shown in FIG. 1.

- (25) In one embodiment, as shown in FIG. 2, the crown section **300AA** may include the fastener **440** on the outer surface **556** proximate to the crown section attaching edge **520A** and on the inner surface **557** proximate to the face section attaching edge **510A**. In addition, the crown section **300BB** may include the fastener **440** on the inner surface **557** proximate to the crown section attaching edge **520B** and proximate to the face section attaching edge **510B**. However, it should be appreciated that such configuration should not be construed as limiting as the fastener **440** may be used in any suitable configuration desired.
- (26) In addition, each of the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** respectively may include ear covers **550A** and **550B**, which are configured to receive therein and accommodate the ears **560** of the horse **10**. The ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of any suitable material, and in some embodiments, it may be formed from the same material as the sections **300** to be discussed, as well as air breathable or porous material, such as mesh or perforated material for example. That is, the ear covers **550A-B** may be permanently attached to the crown sections **300AA-BB**, such as through any suitable means of fixation, including stitching, adhesive, rivets and the like.
- (27) Alternatively, as shown in FIG. 2A, the ear covers **550A-B** may be configured to be removably attached to the crown sections **300AA-BB** by the releasable fastener **440**, such as by hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as, snaps, zippers, clips and the like. As such, when the ear covers **550A-B** are removed from the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB**, corresponding ear openings or apertures **558** are revealed in the crown sections **300AA-BB**, also shown in FIG. 2A. In this case, the ears **560** of the horse **10** may be protrude through the openings or apertures **558** in the crown sections **300AA-BB**.
- (28) In addition, it should be appreciated that in some embodiments of the fly mask **100**, the ear covers **550A-B** may be integrated directly, such as through a sewn attachment for example, to the crown sections **300AA-BB**.
- (29) In other embodiments of the fly mask **100**, the crown sections **300AA-BB** may be configured to include only the ear apertures of openings **558**, without the use of the ear covers **550A-B** being attached thereto.
- (30) In some embodiments, the crown mask portion **460B**, formed by the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB**, may be configured to include a forelock aperture **570**. The forelock aperture **570** is provided to allow a forelock (not shown) of the horse **10** to extend therethrough. In addition, the aperture **570** may be configured as any suitable shape, but in some embodiments the aperture **570** may be annular, triangular, or diamond shaped, thus the aperture **570** may be curvilinear, rectilinear, or a combination of both. In particular, the aperture **570** may be defined by separate forelock aperture segments **570A** and **570B** disposed in respective crown sections **300AA** and **300BB**, shown clearly in FIG. 2. Thus, when the crown section **300AA** and crown section **300BB** are joined together by releasable fastener **440**, as shown in FIGS. 1 and 3, the completed forelock aperture **570** is formed. However, it should be appreciated that in other embodiments, the forelock aperture **570** may be entirely disposed in either one of the crown section **300AA** or the crown section **300BB**.
- (31) It is also contemplated that each crown section **300AA** and **300BB** may be formed of multiple sections instead of the single section shown in the Figs., which are joined by the releasable fastener **440**, which may include hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like.
- (32) Nose Section:
- (33) The fly mask **100** also includes a nose section **300C** to cover, or at least partially cover, a nose **800** of the horse **10**. The nose section **300C** has a face attaching edge **710** and an exterior edge **715**, as well as an inner surface **557** and an outer surface **558**. The face section attaching edge **710** of the nose section **700** includes the releasable fastener **440**, which may include hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like. As such, the nose section **300C** is configured to be removably attached via the face section attaching edge **710** to the nose section

attaching edges **420A-B** of the face sections **300A-B**.

(34) In one embodiment, as shown in FIG. 2, the nose section may include the fastener **440** on the inner surface **557** proximate to the face attaching edge **710**. However, it should be appreciated that such configuration should not be construed as limiting as the fastener **440** may be used in any suitable configuration desired.

(35) In addition, the nose section **700C** may be configured to cover one or more of the top, and in some cases the side portions, of the horse's nose **800**.

(36) It is also contemplated that the nose section **300C** may be configured in as multiple sections instead of the single section shown in the Figs., which are joined by the releasable fastener **440**, which may include hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like.

Alternative Embodiment

(37) In another embodiment of the fly mask referred to by numeral **100'**, it should be appreciated that the face sections **300A-B** (i.e. face mask portion **460A**) may be utilized without the use of the crown sections **300AA-BB** (i.e. crown mask portion), as shown in FIG. 7A. That is, the fly mask **100'** allows the face sections **300A-B** to be properly supported and attached to the animal's face **300** without the use of the crown sections **300AA-BB**. Accordingly, the face sections **300A-B** include a support strap **900** that joins the face section **300A** to the face section **300B**. Specifically, one end **904** of the support strap **900** is attached to the face section **300A** at a point proximate to the lateral extent of the face section **300A**. Similarly, another end **906** of the support strap **900** is attached to the face section **300B** at a point proximate to the lateral extent of the face section **300B**. In some embodiments, the support strap **900** may comprise a flat cross-section having an inner surface **900** and an outer surface **922**. However, it should be appreciated that the support strap **900** may comprise any suitable cross-sectional shape, such as a rectilinear shape, a curvilinear shape or a combination thereof. It should be appreciated that the support strap **900** may also have ends **911** and **912** that allows the support strap to be selectively joined together, such as through any removable fastener, such as hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like. However, the ends **911** and **912** may be removed that the support strap **900** may be a one continuous section.

(38) The support strap **900**, as shown in FIG. 7A, may in some embodiments include any suitable material, such as, leather, nylon, or the like for example. In some embodiments, the support strap **900** may be formed of a resilient material that is stretchable.

(39) In some embodiments, the inner surface **922** of the support strap **900** is configured to be positioned adjacent to the animal when the fly mask **100'** is being worn and may be lined with a soft or padded material in some cases. For example, the lining may comprise cotton material, leather, such as chamois leather, and the like to increase the comfort to the animal **10**.

(40) In alternative embodiments, the crown sections **300AA-BB** may be optionally removably attached to the fly mask **100'**. As such, the outer surface **920** of the support strap **900** that is distal from the animal **10** when the fly mask **100'** is worn includes the releasable fastener **440**. This allows for the removable attachment of the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** to the fly mask **100'**, as shown in FIGS. 7B-C. That is, the crown sections **300AA-BB** of the fly mask **100'** may be configured to include the releasable fastener **440** so that the crown sections **300AA-BB** can be releasably attached to the support strap **900**. Specifically, the releasable fastener **440** is positioned on the inner surface **557** of the crown section **300AA** at a point proximate to its exterior edge **525A** and the face section attaching edge **510A**. Similarly, the releasable fastener **440** is positioned on the inner surface **557** of the crown section **300BB** at a point proximate to its exterior edge **525B** and the face section attaching edge **501B**. As such, the releasable fastener **440** positioned proximate to the exterior edges **525A-B** of the crown sections **300AA-BB** is configured to be attached to the releasable fastener **440** that is positioned on the outer surface **920** of the support strap **900**, as well as to the fastener **400** provided on the outer surface **556** of the face sections **300A-B**, proximate to

the face section attaching edge **510**.

(41) It should also be appreciated that each of the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** configured for use with the fly mask **100'** may include ear covers **550A** and **550B**, which are configured to receive therein and accommodate the ears **560** of the horse **10**. That is, the ear covers **550A-B** may be permanently attached to the crown sections **300AA-BB** through any suitable means of fixation, such as stitching, adhesive, rivets, and the like. Alternatively, the ear covers **550A-B** may be removably attached to the crown sections **300AA-BB** by the releasable fastener **440**, such as by hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as, snaps, zippers, clips, and the like, as previously discussed. It should be appreciated that in some embodiments, kits may be provided, which are discussed in detail below, that include multiple crown sections **300AA-BB** having different sizes that also include ear covers **550** of different sizes.

(42) Options:

(43) It should also be appreciated that the fly mask **100/100'** may also include an information section to include the name or identifying information associated with the horse, as well as any other information that is desired. In some embodiments, the information section may comprise a space, a plate, a section or the like formed of any suitable material. The information section permits a user to place identifying indicia thereon, such as through writing with a pen or marker, or with pre-printed adhesive decals for example. In some embodiments, the information section may be positioned on the fastener **450**, as well as on any other section **300** of the fly mask **100/100'**.

(44) Material:

(45) The various sections **300**, including the face sections **300A-B**, the crown sections **300AA-BB**, the nose section **300C**, and the ear covers **550A-B** of the fly mask **100/100'** may be formed from any suitable material, such as fabric, metal, plastic, polymeric material, or a combination or hybrid thereof. It should also be appreciated that the material used to form one or more of the face sections **300A-B**, the crown sections **300AA-BB**, the nose section **300C**, and the ear covers **550A-B** of the fly mask **100/100'** may comprise light-transparent or at least partially light-transparent material. It should also be appreciated that in some embodiments, the face mask portion **460A**, the crown mask portion **460B**, the nose section **300C** and ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of the same material or may be formed of different materials from each other. For example, the crown mask portion **460B** and/or the nose section **300C** may be formed of opaque material, while the face mask portion **460A** that is positioned over the eyes of the horse **10** is formed of at least partially transparent material. Furthermore, in such an embodiment, the crown mask portion **460B** and/or the nose section **300C** may be formed of light opaque or light blocking material, such as nylon or leather (e.g. chamois leather) for example, while the face mask portion **460A** is formed of an at least partially light-transparent material.

(46) It should also be appreciated that in some embodiments the material used to form the various sections **300**, as well as the ear covers **550A-B**, may encompass stretchable material, such as SPANDEX® or stretch LYCRA® for example, or may be formed of other material, such as fine mesh nylon, cotton, or polyester. For example, in some embodiments, the face sections **300A-B**, crown sections **300AA-BB** and nose section **300C** may be formed of stretchable material, as previously discussed, while the ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of cotton, cotton blend fabric, polyester, or polyester mesh fabric for example.

(47) In some embodiments, one or more of the face sections **300A-B**, crown sections **300AA-BB** and nose section **300C**, and ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of leather (e.g. chamois leather) material, such as perforated leather.

(48) In addition, in some embodiments, the fly mask **100/100'** may be formed, whereby the face mask portion **460A** and the crown mask portion **460B** are both formed of a perforated material or of a porous mesh material. However, in other embodiments, the face mask portion **460A** may be formed of different materials, whereby one of the face mask portion **460A** or the crown mask portion **460B** is formed of porous mesh material, while the other portion is formed of perforated

material. In addition, the ear covers **550A-B** and nose section **300C** may also be formed of porous mesh or perforated material. The porous mesh material and the perforated material are configured to provide breathability and to improve the comfort of the animal wearing the fly mask **100/100'**. (49) It is also contemplated that one or more of the face sections **300A-B**, the crown sections **300AA-BB**, the nose section **300C**, and ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of material that provides UV (ultraviolet) light protection to the animal. That is, the face sections **300A-B**, the crown sections **300AA-BB**, and the nose section **300C** may be treated with UV light resistant or blocking material to prevent the penetration of UV light to the animal wearing the fly mask **100/100'**.

(50) It should be appreciated that the fly mask **100** may be formed of any suitable size and dimension to accommodate horses **10** of different shapes and sizes.

(51) It should also be appreciated that the material used to form the fly mask **100** may have any design or print thereon. In some embodiments, one or more of the sections **300A**, **300B**, **300AA**, **300BB**, **300C** and ear covers **550A-B** may be formed of light reflective material. In some embodiments, one or more edges **400A-B**, **410A-B**, **420A-B** and **425A-B** of the face sections **300A-B** may include reflective material; and/or one or more edges **510A-B**, **520A-B** and **525A-B** of the crown sections **300AA-BB** may include reflective material; and/or one or more edges **710** and **715** of the nose section **300C** may include reflective material.

(52) Lining and Padding:

(53) As previously discussed, the fly mask **100/100'** formed by the face sections **300A** and **300B** (face mask portion **460A**), the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** (crown mask portion **460B**), the nose section **300C** and the ear covers **550A-B** has an outer surface **556** and an inner surface **557**. The inner surface **557** of the fly mask **100/100'** is configured to be placed adjacent to the animal's head **120**. Furthermore, the inner surface **557** may be configured to include a lining material thereon. In addition, the lining material may be positioned adjacent to one or more edges of the various sections **300A-B**, **300AA-BB**, **300C** and the ear cover openings **558** of the fly mask **100/100'**. In other words, the lining material may be placed on the inner surface **557** of the fly mask **100/100'** and/or positioned adjacent to one or more of the edges **400A-B**, **410A-B**, **420A-B** and **425A-B** of the face sections **300A-B**; positioned adjacent to one or more of the edges **510A-B**, **520A-B**, and **525A-B** of the crown sections **300AA-BB**; and adjacent to one or more of the edges **710** and **715** of the nose section **300C**. In addition, the lining material may be positioned on the inner surface **557** of the fly mask **100/100'** and proximate to the ear openings **558**.

(54) It should also be appreciated that the lining material may comprise any suitable material that is different than that used to form the various sections **300**. In some embodiments, the lining material may comprise any suitable material that is softer than the material used to form the various fly mask sections **300**. In some cases, the lining material may include leather (e.g. chamois leather), fleece material, polyester material, cotton material or a combination thereof. In other embodiments, the lining material may be padded with a separate material, such as foam or other resilient material, to improve the comfort to the animal **10** when the fly mask **100/100'** is worn.

(55) Removable Section Configuration:

(56) Accordingly, the fly mask **100/100'** is configured from the various sections **300** (i.e. **300A**, **300B**, **300AA**, **300BB**, and **300C**) and ear covers **550A-B**, which are each removably joined or attached to one another by the releasable fastener **440**, such as hook and loop material (e.g. VELCRO®), as well as snaps, zippers, clips and the like. This allows a user to easily and conveniently remove and replace a particular section **300** (i.e. **300A**, **300B**, **300AA**, **300BB**, and **300C**) and ear cover **550A-B** of the fly mask **100**, such as in the case where they become worn or damaged through use, without the need to replace the entire fly mask **100**.

(57) It should be appreciated that in some embodiments only the face mask portion **460A** may be utilized to form the fly mask **10** without the need to use the crown mask portion **460B** or the nose section **300C**. Alternatively, it should be appreciated that the face mask portion **460A** may be used

with one or more of the crown mask portion **460B** or the nose section **300C** as desired by the user.

(58) Kit:

(59) In other embodiments, it should be appreciated that the fly mask **100/100'** may be provided as an unassembled kit of one or more of the sections **300A**, **300B**, **300AA**, **300BB** and **300C**. In some embodiments, the kit may include the face sections **300A** and **300B** (face mask portion **460A**), the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** (crown mask portion **460B**), and the nose section **300C**. In other embodiments, the kit may include the face sections **300A** and **300B** (face mask portion **460A**), and the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** (crown mask portion **460B**). And in other embodiments the kit may include the crown sections **300AA** and **300BB** (crown mask portion **460B**) and the nose section **300C**. It should be appreciated that in some embodiments, the kits may optionally include removable ear covers **550A-B**. Still yet, it should be appreciated that the kit may include various ridged/molded protrusions or lens previously discussed.

(60) It is also contemplated that a kit may provide multiple sets of face sections **300A-B**, multiple sets of crown sections **300AA-BB**, multiple nose sections **300C**, and multiple ear covers **550A-B** that are each of different sizes to accommodate animals, such as horses, having different head, crown, nose and ear dimensions. For example, a given kit may include multiple face sections **300A-B** of different sizes; a given kit may include multiple crown sections **300AA-BB** of different sizes; a given kit may include multiple nose sections **300C** of different sizes; a given kit may include multiple crown sections **300AA-BB** having different sizes, which also include ear covers **550** of different sizes; and it is contemplated that kits of any one or more of the foregoing may be provided.

(61) In addition, kits having sections **300** and ear covers **550** of different dimensions allows the fly mask **100/100'** to achieve a customized and comfortable fit for the animal **10**, which is highly desirable. Providing various kits having multiple face sections **300A-B**, multiple crown sections **300AA-BB**, multiple nose sections **300C**, and multiple ear covers **550A-B** of different shapes/sizes allows the fly mask **100/100'** to provide a customized fit to a variety of animals. For example, the kit could accommodate horses of various shapes/sizes, as well as mules, zebras, donkeys and the like of all shapes/sizes.

(62) It should also be appreciated that kits may also be configured to include a single/individual or multiple replacement components, such as replacement face sections **300A** and/or **300B**, replacement crown sections **300AA** and/or **300BB**, replacement nose section **300C** and a replacement ear sections **550A** and/or **550B**. Such individual replacement sections **300** and ear covers **550A-B** allow the fly mask **100/100'** to be readily maintained when it is worn or damaged, which is highly convenient.

(63) Use:

(64) To place the fly mask **100/100'** into use, it is assembled from the face mask portion **460A**, the crown mask portion **460B** and the nose section **300C**, which are attached together via the fastener **440**. The completed face mask **100/100'** is placed on the head **120** of the horse **10**, such that the ear covers **550A-B** receive the horse's ears **560** therein, while the nose section **300C** is positioned over or proximate to the horse's nose **800**. The face sections **300A** and **300B** are then attached to each other in front of the horse's neck **480** using the retention device or fastener **450** as shown in FIGS. **3-4**.

(65) Thus, during use, the fly mask **100'** is placed on the head **120** of the animal **10**, such as a horse, whereby the support strap **900** is placed over rear portion **940** of the horse's neck **480** and behind the ears **560** of the horse **10**. In addition, the ears **560** of the horse **10** are placed through the openings **558** in the crown section **300AA-BB**. Finally, the retaining straps **450A-B** are attached together by the fastener **470** to secure the face sections **300A-B** together as previously discussed, thereby attaching the face mask portion **460A** to the horse **10**.

(66) Optionally, the crown sections **300AA-BB** of the fly mask **100'** may be removed, leaving the face sections **300A-B** remaining and attached to the head **120** of the horse **10** by the support strap

900 and the retaining straps 450A-B. As such, the fly mask 100' allows the face sections 300A-B to be used with or without the crown sections 300AA-BB.

(67) Therefore, it can be seen that the objects of the various embodiments disclosed herein have been satisfied by the structure and its method for use presented above. While in accordance with the Patent Statutes, only the best mode and preferred embodiments have been presented and described in detail, with it being understood that the embodiments disclosed herein are not limited thereto or thereby. Accordingly, for an appreciation of the true scope and breadth of the embodiments, reference should be made to the following claims.

Claims

1. A fly mask for an animal comprising: a first face section having a first edge; a first elongated fastener attached to said first edge; a second face section having a second edge; a second elongated fastener attached to said second edge, wherein said first elongated fastener and said second elongated fastener are configured to be removably attached to each other, and wherein when said first and second elongated fasteners are attached together said first edge and said second edge overlap each other and extend over the face and between the eyes of the animal, wherein said first face section includes a first edge fastener, and said second face section includes a second edge fastener; a fastener device attached to said first and second face sections, said fastener device adapted to releasably attach said first and second face sections together proximate to the neck of the animal; a first crown section having a first crown fastener; a second crown section having a second crown fastener, wherein said second crown section is removably attached to said first crown section; a first support strap attached to said first face section, wherein said first support strap includes a first strap fastener; and a second support strap attached to said second face section, wherein said second support strap includes a second strap fastener, wherein said first and second support straps are removably attachable to each other, and wherein when said first and second support straps are attached to each other, said first and second support straps rest upon the head and are positioned behind the ears of the animal, and wherein said attached first and second support straps together with an edge of said first and second face sections define an opening through which the crown of the head of the animal extends therethrough, and wherein said first crown fastener of said first crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said first edge fastener and said first strap fastener, and said second crown fastener of said second crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said second edge fastener and said second strap fastener.
2. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first and second crown sections each include an opening adapted to receive an ear of the animal therethrough.
3. The fly mask of claim 2, further comprising an ear cover removably attached to each said opening, wherein said ear covers are configured to receive the ears of the animal therein.
4. The fly mask of claim 1, further comprising: a nose section removably attached to at least one of said face sections, said nose section adapted to be positioned proximate to the nose of the animal.
5. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first and second face sections comprise at least partially light-transparent material.
6. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first and second face sections comprise porous material.
7. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first and second face sections comprise fabric.
8. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first elongated fastener extends the full length of said first elongated edge, and wherein said second elongated fastener extends the full length of said second elongated edge.
9. The fly mask of claim 1, wherein said first elongated fastener and said second elongated fastener are hook and loop fasteners.
10. A fly mask kit for an animal comprising: a first face section having a first edge; a second face

section having a second edge; a first elongated fastener attached to said first edge; a second elongated fastener attached to said second edge, wherein said first elongated fastener and said second elongated fastener are configured to be removably attached to each other, and wherein when said first and second elongated fasteners are attached together said first edge and said second edge overlap each other and extend over the face and between the eyes of the animal, wherein said first and second face sections are configured to be removably joined together proximate to the neck of the animal, and wherein said first face section includes a first edge fastener, and said second face section includes a second edge fastener; a first crown section having a first crown fastener; a second crown section having a second crown fastener, wherein said second crown section is configured to be removably attached to said first crown section; a first support strap attached to said first face section, wherein said first support strap includes a first strap fastener; and a second support strap attached to said second face section, wherein said second support strap includes a second strap fastener, and wherein said first and second support straps are configured to be removably attachable to each other; wherein when said first and second support straps are attached to each other, said first and second support straps rest upon the head and are positioned behind the ears of the animal, and wherein said attached first and second support straps together with and edge of said first and second face sections define an opening through which the crown of the head of the animal extends therethrough, and wherein said first crown fastener of said first crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said first edge fastener and said first strap fastener, and said second crown fastener of said second crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said second edge fastener and said second strap fastener.

11. The fly mask kit of claim 10, further comprising: a nose section configured to be removably attached to at least one of said first and second face sections, said nose section adapted to be positioned proximate to the nose of the animal.

12. The fly mask kit of claim 11, wherein said first and second face sections comprise at least partially light-transparent material.

13. The fly mask kit of claim 11, further comprising a plurality of said first face sections and a plurality of said second face sections, wherein said plurality of said first face sections and said plurality of said second face sections are different sizes.

14. The fly mask kit of claim 11, further comprising a plurality of said first crown sections and a plurality of said second crown sections, wherein said plurality of said first crown sections and said plurality of said second crown sections are different sizes.

15. The fly mask kit of claim 11, further comprising a plurality of said nose sections that are different sizes.

16. The fly mask kit of claim 10, wherein said first and second crown sections each include an opening adapted to receive an ear of the animal therethrough.

17. The fly mask kit of claim 16, further comprising: an ear cover configured to be removably attached to each said opening, wherein said ear covers are configured to receive the ears of the animal therein.

18. A fly mask kit for an animal comprising: a first face section having a first elongated edge; a second face section having a second elongated edge; a first elongated fastener attached to said first face section extending parallel to said first elongated edge; a second elongated fastener attached to said second face section extending parallel to said second elongated edge, wherein said first elongated fastener and said second elongated fastener are configured to be removably attached to each other, and wherein when said first and second elongated fasteners are attached together said first edge and said second edge overlap each other and extend over the face and between the eyes of the animal, wherein said first and second face sections are configured to be removably joined together proximate to the neck of the animal, wherein said first face section includes a first edge fastener, and said second face section includes a second edge fastener; a first crown section having a first crown fastener; a second crown section having a second crown fastener, wherein said second

crown section is configured to be removably attached to said first crown section; a first support strap attached to said first face section, wherein said first support strap includes a first strap fastener; a second support strap attached to said second face section, wherein said second support strap includes a second strap fastener, and wherein said first and second support straps are configured to be removably attachable to each other, wherein when said first and second support straps are attached to each other, said first and second support straps rest upon the head and are positioned behind the ears of the animal, and wherein said attached first and second support straps together with an edge of said first and second face sections define an opening through which the crown of the head of the animal extends therethrough, wherein said first crown fastener of said first crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said first edge fastener and said first strap fastener, and said second crown fastener of said second crown section is configured to be removably attached to at least said second edge fastener and said second strap fastener.

19. The fly mask kit of claim 18, further comprising: a nose section configured to be removably attached to at least one of said first and second face sections, said nose section adapted to be positioned proximate to the nose of the animal.
